Houthi Red Sea Disruption

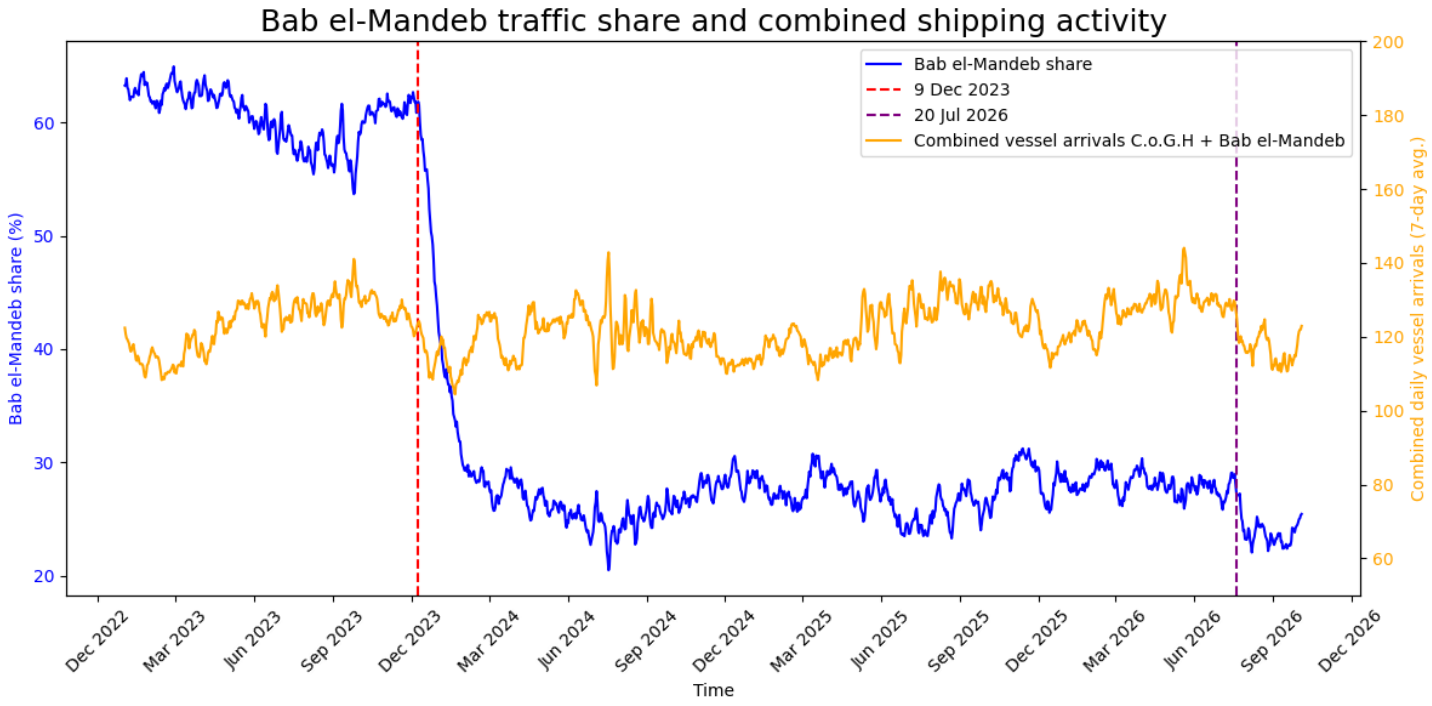
14 November 2023
Houthis declare targeting of all Israeli-owned ships in the Strait of Bab el-Mandeb.

18 January 2024
Inclusion of any UK- and US-owned ships

(IISS 2024)

9 December 2023
Targeting expands to any Israel-bound ships and vessels providing protection to Israeli shipping.

3 May 2024
Houthis extend targeting to any vessel operated by shipping companies calling at Israeli ports & Palestinian ports occupied by Israel



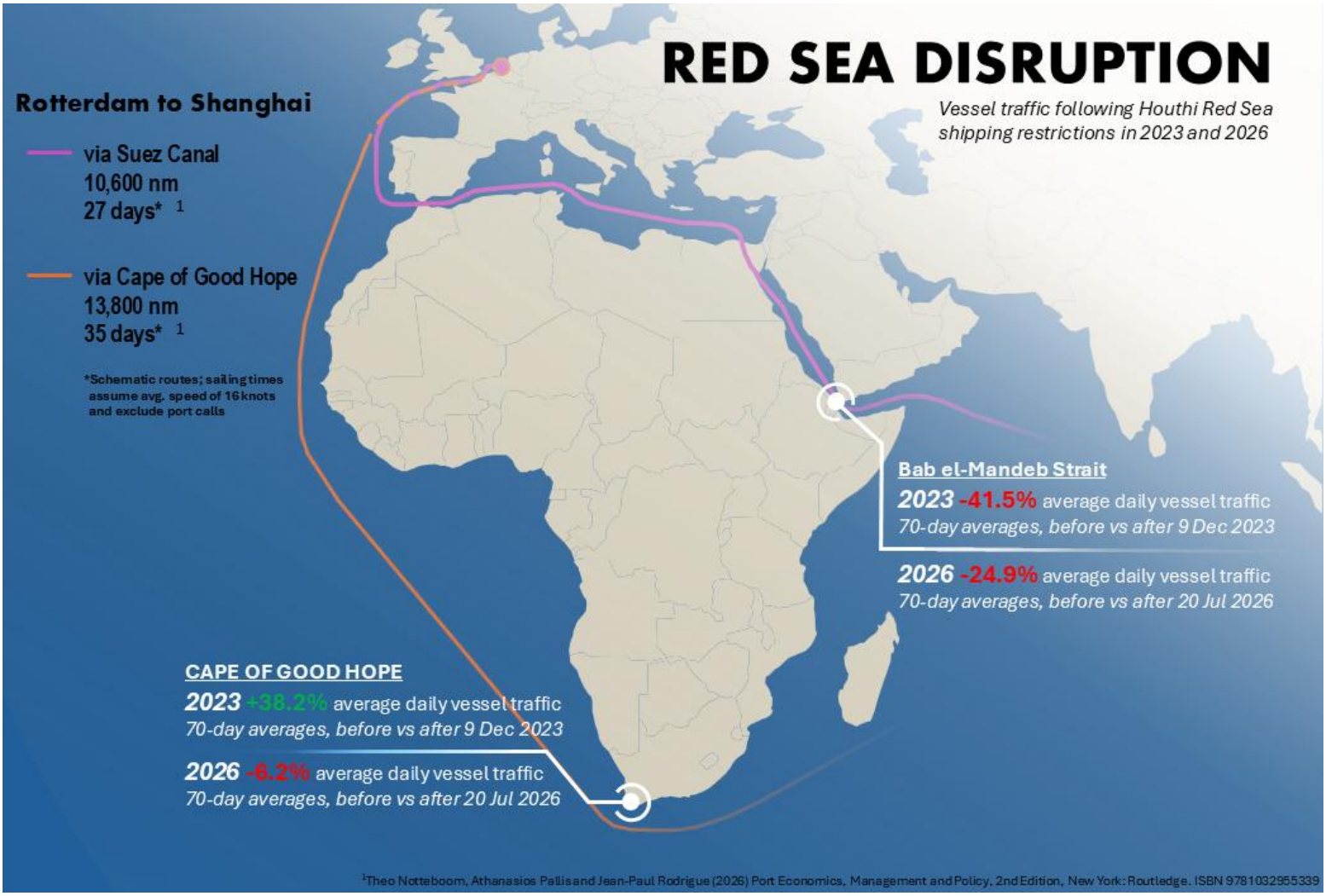
Share of traffic between Strait of Bab el-Mandeb and Cape of Good Hope. Data-source: Portwatch

As Houthi-target discrimination eroded, major operators of commercial shipping vessels rerouted around the Cape of Good Hope.

"Having monitored developments closely and retrieved all available intelligence, Maersk has decided that all vessels previously paused and due to sail through [the Red Sea / Gulf of Aden] will now be re-routed around Africa via the Cape of Good Hope for safety reasons." **- 19 Dec 2023 announcement by Maersk**

On 20 Jul 2026, Houthi spokespeople renewedly announced a retaliatory embargo on Saudi-operated vessels. In September, Houthi-forces made significant advances along Yemen's coastline, gaining substantially more leverage over the adjacent seaways. This time, the group was quick to clarify that the Strait offered safe passage for all non-Saudi shipping companies. **(Reuters 2026)**

Given the lack of rerouting and decreased overall traffic this time around, the coming months may reveal whether clearer Houthi targeting signals and diplomatic backchannels have fostered greater confidence among shipping operators as opposed to 2023, causing vessels to wait out instead of rerouting and traffic levels to eventually recover.



International Monetary Fund (IMF). 2026. *PortWatch: Monitoring Trade Disruptions from Space.* Washington, DC: International Monetary Fund

IISS (2024). *Navigating Troubled Waters: The Houthis' Campaign in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden.* International Institute for Strategic Studies, December 2024.

Reuters 2026. "Yemen's Houthis Close In on Bab el-Mandeb Strait in New Threat to Shipping." September 10, 2026.